DHL Express · IT Team Lead Interview Prep

H&G NEXUS · Team North Star use case · Brussels Q4 2026

Anjish Bhondwe · 20-minute presentation + 90-minute interview · Diegem, on-site role

1. What the role expects (JD)

This is a **people leadership and team enablement** role, not a pure delivery or architecture role. You lead Software Solution Engineers so the team becomes future-fit and a trusted supplier of digital solutions.

- **Direction:** set a clear team vision, align to department strategy, inspire ownership.
- **People leadership:** coach, mentor, performance conversations, development plans, engagement.
- **Psychological safety:** create a safe space for open dialogue inside the team and with stakeholders.
- **Enablement:** help the team succeed under pressure; remove obstacles and resolve conflict.
- **Craft and delivery quality:** oversee planning and completion from an abilities and craftsmanship angle (skills fit, quality, sustainability), not only timeline chasing.
- **Leadership Team member:** contribute to department leadership evolution, not only your team silo.
- **Mindset they want:** adapt in a dynamic environment, share knowledge, co-create ways of working, stay curious about tech and people practices.

> INTERVIEW SIGNAL
>
> Show you lead people and culture first, protect business continuity, and still care about product craft. Avoid sounding like a classic project manager or a ceremony-only Scrum Master.

2. Use case goal (must stay visible throughout)

- **Goal:** evolve Team North Star into a fit-for-purpose development team by **end-June 2027**.
- **Capability bar:** every SSE at least **Competent (Dreyfus level 3)** to develop and support products under their responsibility.
- **Key success factor: business continuity** before, during and after the new organization.
- **Your seat:** newly joined Team Lead of North Star + member of the H&G NEXUS Leadership Team.

3. Mandatory content in your 20-minute presentation

1. Key assumptions
2. Approach to understanding the team and context
3. Short-term and long-term actions
4. How you measure progress and success
5. Your leadership style and mindset
6. Stakeholder management (alignment, decisions, communication)
7. Knowledge development, onboarding, documentation, eliminate single points of failure

If any of these seven are missing, the panel will notice. Build the deck around them, not around a generic transformation story.

4. Current team facts (memorize)

Product	Today	Target sizing	Notes
A	6 SSEs (2 employees + 4 consultants). Mix Java/IBMi. Heavy debt, large regulatory and cost-savings backlog. PO in Belgium.	9 SSEs (7 IBMi + 2 Java). At least 4 proficient.	Biggest risk and biggest knowledge concentration. After-hours today depends on few people.
B	2 SSEs IBMi, both proficient, strong product knowledge. PO in Germany.	2–3 IBMi SSEs. At least 1 proficient.	Smaller, healthier baseline.
C	2 consultant SSEs IBMi, competent, strong product knowledge. PO in Germany.	2 IBMi SSEs. At least 1 proficient.	Limited scope, medium complexity.

- 10 SSEs total today: 9 Belgium, 1 UK. Work as sub-teams by product.
- Only **4 SSEs** do after-hours support today. **4 SSEs** refuse after-hours (temporary or completely). Continuity risk.
- New consulting SOWs already require after-hours once knowledge is fit for purpose. New joiners align to revised SSE role.

5. Challenges you must name and address

- Solo-working culture and maximizing individual utilization
- Under pressure, learning and reflection are skipped (“after this project”)
- Informal two-tier hierarchy based on product knowledge depth (affects how stakeholders treat people)
- After-hours coverage concentrated and contested
- Need all SSEs at minimum Competent, with mindset/behaviors aligned to department ambition

6. Suggested 20-minute storyline

1. **0–2 min · Open:** Restate goal, June 2027 date, business continuity as non-negotiable, your role as people lead + LT member.
2. **2–4 min · Assumptions:** List 5–7 clear assumptions (see page 3).
3. **4–6 min · Diagnose first:** How you learn the team, products, POs, support reality, skills map (Dreyfus).
4. **6–12 min · Action plan:** 0–90 days, then to June 2027 by product and by people capability.
5. **12–15 min · Continuity + knowledge:** after-hours roadmap, pairing, docs, remove SPOFs, onboarding.
6. **15–17 min · Stakeholders:** POs BE/DE, LT peers, other NEXUS teams, how decisions and heartbeats work.
7. **17–19 min · Measures + leadership:** what you track; how you lead (safe space, accountability, craft).
8. **19–20 min · Close:** one sentence on outcomes by June 2027 and invite questions.

TIMING TIP

Do not spend half the time on Product A technical debt. Spend equal energy on people enablement, continuity, and culture. That matches the JD.

7. Assumptions you can state (adapt live)

- Budget and headcount to move Product A toward 9 SSEs is possible within the planning cycle, or LT will decide trade-offs explicitly.
- POs remain accountable for product priority; Team Lead owns people, craft capability, and team ways of working.
- Business continuity includes production support, after-hours, regulatory/cost-savings commitments on Product A.
- Existing proficient people will coach others if we protect time for knowledge transfer (not only delivery utilization).
- Consultants on new SOWs will do after-hours once competent; employee after-hours needs fair roster design and dialogue, not force without support.
- IBMi remains core for A/B/C; Java capacity on A must be intentional (target 2 Java SSEs).
- You have LT peer support to align cross-team sourcing and shared standards (NEXUS “AS ONE”).

8. First 30–90 days: understand team and context

- **Listen tour:** 1:1 with each SSE, each PO (BE + DE), LT peers, key stakeholders. Ask: what works, what breaks, where knowledge sits, what scares people about after-hours.
- **Skills and product map:** Dreyfus score per person per product/module/tech (IBMi, Java). Mark SPOFs in red.
- **Support reality check:** who is on after-hours, load, refusal reasons, incident patterns.
- **Flow and demand:** Product A backlog shape (regulatory vs cost savings vs debt), WIP, solo work patterns.
- **Team agreements draft:** how we plan, review, learn, give feedback, escalate. Co-create, do not impose day one.

Speak line: “I will not reorganize before I understand where continuity risk and knowledge risk actually sit.”

9. Short-term actions (to ~end Q1 / Q2 2027 start)

- Stabilize after-hours: transparent roster principles, pair primary/backup, training path for people not yet ready; separate “cannot yet” from “will not”.
- Protect weekly knowledge time (pairing, shadowing, docs). Make it a heartbeat, not optional after delivery.
- Start SPOF reduction on Product A modules owned by only one proficient person.
- Clarify role expectations against the revised SSE profile with every team member.
- Agree PO collaboration routines (BE/DE): priorities, Definition of Ready/Done, escalation path.
- Performance and development: individual growth plans toward Competent minimum, with proficient coaching targets on A/B/C.

10. Longer-term actions (to end-June 2027)

- Hire / engage to target sizing, especially Product A (IBMi depth + Java). Prefer people who accept support duty per new SOW/role.
- Move every SSE to ≥ Competent on their product responsibility; lift Product A to ≥ 4 proficient.
- Broaden after-hours to all SSEs who are knowledge-fit; document runbooks.
- Reduce solo-hero culture: shared ownership, cross-product learning where useful, celebrate team outcomes.
- Address technical debt on A with PO jointly, in balance with regulatory and cost-savings demand (explicit trade-offs).
- As LT member: share practices with Wings / Phoenix / Automation / Artemis; source across teams when needed.

11. Knowledge, onboarding, documentation, no SPOF

- **Onboarding path:** product overview, architecture, support playbook, buddy/proficient coach, first safe change, then support shadow shifts.
- **Documentation standard:** runbooks, module ownership map, decision log, “how we recover” for incidents. Co-create with SSEs (SSE profile expects this).
- **Eliminate SPOF:** every critical module has primary + backup at ≥ Competent; track until true.
- **Learning under pressure:** when urgent work arrives, still keep a thin learning slice; otherwise the “after this project” trap continues.
- **Two-tier hierarchy:** value deep knowledge, but stop stakeholders routing only to “heroes.” Train backups and redirect requests to the team channel.

12. Stakeholder management notes

Stakeholder	Need	Your move
POs (1 BE, 2 DE)	Predictable delivery, clear capacity, quality	Joint priority sessions; honest capacity including learning and support time
SSEs	Clarity, fairness, growth, safe voice	1:1s, growth plans, recognition of teaming not only heroics
NEXUS LT peers	Department “AS ONE”, shared standards	Bring North Star issues early; borrow/lend skills across teams
Business / ops / compliance	Continuity, regulatory confidence	Visible support model; no silent single points of failure

Decision-making: product what/why with PO; how with team; people and craft standards with you; department trade-offs in LT.

Communication heartbeat: team standup/planning cadence, PO sync (include DE timezone respect), LT update, monthly skills/continuity dashboard.

13. How to measure progress and success

Capability

- % SSEs ≥ Competent per product
- Count of proficient SSEs vs target (esp. Product A ≥ 4)
- Modules with primary + backup

Continuity

- After-hours coverage % and refusal trend
- Incident MTTR / repeat incidents
- Support load fairness

Team health

- Engagement / eNPS or pulse
- Learning hours kept vs planned
- Feedback culture signals (1:1 themes)

Delivery craft

- Predictability vs PO commitments
- Quality escapes / rework
- Debt reduction items completed with PO

14. Leadership style to show (aligned to DHL / NEXUS DNA)

- Servant and accountable: remove obstacles, still hold standards and role clarity.
- Psychological safety + candor: invite challenge, give feedback as a gift, no blame theatre.
- Teams over heroes: reward pairing, docs, backups, shared wins.
- Can-do with realism: protect continuity while growing people; do not promise June 2027 magic without trade-offs.
- Department-minded: North Star success should help NEXUS be supplier of choice, not a local island.

Speak line: “My job is to grow competent, confident engineers and a team that can support the business at 2 a.m. without burning the same four people.”

15. After-hours: sensitive but central

- Acknowledge the risk openly: 4 on roster, 4 refusing = continuity gap.
- Path: knowledge-first readiness → shadow → secondary → primary. Do not put unprepared people on nights.
- For refusals: listen (life situation vs principle vs fear of knowledge gap). Separate employee dialogue from consultant SOW obligations.
- Fairness: rotate, compensate/recognize per company policy, publish calendar early, keep runbooks excellent.
- End-state: all knowledge-fit SSEs participate; new joiners join the model by design.

16. Dreyfus language to use in the room

Level	Meaning (use their words)
0–1	No knowledge / Novice
2	Advanced Beginner: understands concepts
3 Competent	Can apply concepts and train others (minimum bar for all)
4 Proficient	Share best practices, train/coach elements, co-create solutions
5 Specialist	Train/coach peers, develop new methods

17. Likely panel questions (prep short answers)

- How do you handle someone strong on Product A who blocks knowledge sharing?
- What if headcount for 9 on Product A is denied?
- How do you balance regulatory backlog vs skill building?
- How would you work with German POs remotely?
- Give an example of building psychological safety while raising performance.
- How have you reduced single points of failure before?
- What does “supplier of choice for digital solutions” mean in your leadership behavior?

18. Map your experience (speak from evidence)

- **KBC:** multi-country people leadership, onshore-offshore enablement, transfer of activities, coaching maturity, SteerCo stakeholder packs.
- **iostring:** CoE / ways of working, building teams and coaches, India operation leadership.
- **Colruyt RTE / scaled delivery:** cross-team coordination and dependency clarity.
- Always close the loop to: people growth, continuity, craft, and honest stakeholder alignment.

19. Closing sentence you can use

“By June 2027 I want North Star to be a team where every engineer is at least competent on their product, after-hours is a shared professional duty with real backups, and business continuity never depends on a hero. I will get there by listening first, protecting learning time, growing people deliberately, and aligning POs and the Leadership Team on trade-offs in the open.”

DAY-OF CHECKLIST

- Print or keep this pack + one-page timeline (90 days / June 2027)
- Slides: max 8–10; talk, do not read
- Hit all 7 required presentation topics
- Say “business continuity” early and often with a concrete mechanism
- Leave 1 minute for a crisp close